suddenly announced he wanted to work on a new free-kick routine that involved someone flicking the ball up and me volleying it over the wall and in. I was worried about a tight hamstring; in fact none of us had warmed up. So when he told me to do it, I just lobbed the ball over the wall rather than hitting it with full power. Glenn got really angry:

'Can't you do it? Well, if you can't do it, we'll forget it.'

I hadn't done what he wanted me to, because the last thing I needed was to injure myself. The atmosphere between us was strained afterwards, even though Glenn didn't mention it again. It was the kind of clash that players remember: not just the ones directly involved but their team-mates, too, who were standing watching it happen. Despite that, I felt I was worth my place in the next game and just kept my fingers crossed.

England vs Argentina is always a huge game, for all sorts of reasons; not all of them to do with soccer. It's one of the oldest and greatest rivalries in the game. In Argentina, what we call 'derbies' they call 'classicos': not just games between neighbors, like United vs City or England vs Scotland, but fixtures with a history, like United vs Liverpool or England vs Germany. They reckon there's only one 'classico' between teams from two different continents: and that's Us against Them. No wonder it gets a big build-up and that the game in Saint-Etienne in 1998 was no different. I was really excited and looking forward to it. I'd been made to feel insecure and had suffered emotional knocks since the start of the tournament. But I didn't, for a moment, feel anything but ready for Argentina. I certainly didn't have any idea what lay in store for me, during the game and after.

The evening started so well: a great game and us more than a match for them. After Argentina had taken the lead after only five minutes through a Batistuta penalty, Alan Shearer equalized, also from the spot. Over a year had gone by since his last penalty for England, but we all knew he'd lash it in. Then, five minutes later, I put the ball through for Michael Owen to score that fantastic second goal. They got one back and it was 2–2 at half-time. In the dressing room, there were a few words said about the defending at the free-kick from which Zanetti scored their second goal. Otherwise, we just couldn't wait to go out and get started again: the game was there to be won. How could I have known that, for me, disaster was waiting to happen?

I think Diego Simeone is a good player. Good, but really annoying to play against: always round you, tapping your ankles, niggling away at you. It gets to opposition players and he knows it. Maybe, too, he was aware that Glenn